

# The Legend of SACHIN

India's greatest sporting icon and role model completes two record-breaking decades in cricket. An assessment of Tendulkar's place in history and his amazing career.

By Harsha Bhogle

**O**f the many constituents of greatness, longevity is the first to be cast aside. The connoisseurs will talk of grace and beauty and finesse; the fans will talk of numbers, Test runs, majors, grand slams, Olympic medals; the storytellers will regale you with legendary battles won and the romantics might slip in a word for brave efforts that just fell short. But longevity? That's for machines, isn't it? Surely you can't say Sachin Tendulkar is great because he played for 20 years, can you? How boring!

And yet that is my thesis. That longevity assumes all the qualities that everyone else finds dear. If you are good enough to play at the highest level for 20 years you must possess virtually every quality in a sportsman. So you can look back at all of Tendulkar's great innings, you can recall all the snapshots you have stored in your mind, you can trawl through his statistics but the fact that he has put body and mind together and existed as one of the brightest in our pantheon for 20 years is, quite simply, staggering.

It means he has competed against the best in the world across different eras; against grizzly pros when he was a kid and brash, irreverent young men now; he has played on feverishly seaming pitches and on

**He has scored the highest number of centuries in both Test and ODI cricket.**